

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Girl Who Was Mean to Priya in Fourth Grade

Priya, in March, had a different version of the forgiveness work.

Priya was not forgiving herself. Priya, on her paper in Room 104, had written about a kid who had been mean to her in fourth grade. The kid's name was Olivia. Not the new-Olivia who was now at the cohort lunch table — a different Olivia, from elementary school, who had moved away after sixth grade. This Olivia had been, for several months in fourth grade, the kid who had decided that Priya was a target.

The targeting had been specific. Olivia had made fun of Priya's lunch — Priya's mother packed her roti and aloo sometimes, which Olivia had laughed at and called *that weird brown food*. Olivia had, on several days at recess, told other girls not to play with Priya. Olivia had — and this was the worst one — taken Priya's notebook on a Tuesday in October of fourth grade and had drawn on Priya's drawings, ruining several pages of Priya's careful pencil work.

Priya, at nine, had cried at home about Olivia for weeks.

Priya, at nine, had not known what to do about Olivia. Priya had — eventually, in November — told Ms. Calloway about the notebook incident. Ms. Calloway had handled it. Olivia had

been spoken to. Olivia had been required to apologize. Olivia had, in front of Priya and Ms. Calloway, said *I am sorry*.

The apology had been — even to nine-year-old Priya — clearly fake. Olivia had said *I am sorry* the way kids say *I am sorry* when an adult is making them. The eyes had not been sorry. The body language had been *I would do it again if I could*. The apology had not been real. Olivia had, in the weeks after, been less openly mean to Priya — because she had been watched — but had not become any nicer in private. Olivia had simply moved her meanness to small unwitnessed moments.

The targeting had continued, in muted form, through the rest of fourth grade and into fifth grade. Olivia had moved away at the end of sixth grade. Priya had not seen her since.

This was — and Priya had not, until the forgiveness unit in Room 104, articulated it this way — this was the origin story of the Inner Critic.

The Inner Critic in Priya's head had, since fourth grade, used language that was Olivia's. The Critic, when she was at her loudest, said things like *you are weird, your food is gross, nobody wants to play with you, your drawings are bad and somebody could ruin them*. These were not, in Priya's mind, original Critic-thoughts. These were, in some real way, Olivia-quotes that the Critic had been recycling for five years.

Priya had been hearing Olivia's voice in her own head since fourth grade.

She had not, until March of freshman year, known what to call this.

She wrote, on the forgiveness paper:

Olivia, in fourth grade, was mean to me. The meanness lasted, in various forms, from October of fourth grade until she moved away in sixth. The meanness has continued, after she moved, in my own head. The Inner Critic in my head uses

Olivia's words. The Inner Critic has been Olivia, in some real way, for five years.

Today I am writing the forgiveness paper about forgiving Olivia. Or maybe — I am not sure yet — about forgiving the Critic.

She paused.

She wrote:

I want to think about what forgiveness means here. Olivia, for years, never apologized in a real way. Olivia, by all evidence, did not feel sorry. Olivia just moved away. The relationship had no closure. Olivia, in some real way, was not finished with her meanness toward me — she just left town.

Ms. Calloway, in third grade, taught us that forgiveness and trust are not the same. That you can forgive somebody without trusting them again. That the forgiveness is for you, not for them.

I want to forgive Olivia.

Not because Olivia deserves forgiveness. Olivia does not, by any measure of did the work, deserve forgiveness. Olivia, by all reports, has not done the work.

I want to forgive Olivia because the Critic in my head has been paid by Olivia for five years. The Critic has been running, all this time, on Olivia's words. Forgiving Olivia is, in some real way, firing the Critic. Telling the Critic that Olivia's words are no longer authorized. Telling the Critic that her contract is up.

The forgiveness is for me.

It is also — and this is the part I am writing in real time — it is also a strategic move against the Critic. If I stop being mad at Olivia, the Critic loses some of her power. The Critic's power, in some real way, has been built out of my unfinished anger at Olivia. If I finish the anger by forgiving, the Critic has less to work with.

She read it.

She thought about it for a long time.

She wrote:

Forgiving Olivia.

Olivia – wherever you are – you were nine when you were mean to me. You were probably going through your own thing. I do not know what. I will never know what. Whatever it was, you took it out on me and on my lunch and on my notebook. That was not okay. That was, to a nine-year-old me, a real injury.

I am, at fifteen, putting the injury down. The injury is no longer going to live in me. I am – and I am writing this as I think it – I am revoking your permission to be in my head. The Critic in my head has been using your voice. Starting today, the Critic does not get to use your voice. The Critic has to find her own words. Your words are revoked.

Your meanness was nine-year-old meanness. I am, at fifteen, no longer subject to it. I forgive you. I do not trust you. I do not want to know you. I do not need to hear from you. I do not need you to apologize. The forgiveness is mine to give. I am giving it. I am giving it because I am taking my head back.

– Priya

She read it. She read it three times. She read it once out loud, in a whisper, at her desk.

She had not expected, this morning, to be doing this work today. She had expected to do some version of the forgiveness assignment. She had not expected to write a *Dear Olivia* letter that was, in some real way, an exorcism.

The Critic had been quiet, in Priya's head, the entire time she was writing.

This was unusual.

The Critic had been quiet for – Priya checked the clock – twenty-eight minutes. The Critic had not, in five years, been

quiet for twenty-eight uninterrupted minutes during the daytime.

The Critic was — Priya now realized — the Critic was *afraid of this letter*.

Priya almost laughed.

She thought, in her head, *the Critic is afraid. The Critic knows what I just did. The Critic is, in some real way, the kid who was just told she has to find new material because her old material has been revoked.*

Priya put the paper in her notebook.

The bell rang.

After class, Ms. Calloway said, Priya. *Can you stay for a minute.*

Priya stayed.

Ms. Calloway said, Priya. *I do not need to read your paper. I just want to ask you — are you okay?*

Priya said, Ms. Calloway. *I just did something. I am — I think I am okay. I think I might be more than okay.*

Ms. Calloway said, *tell me.*

Priya told her.

Ms. Calloway listened.

When Priya was done, Ms. Calloway said, Priya. *What you just figured out is one of the deepest things in psychology. The fact that the Inner Critic has been using somebody else's voice. The fact that forgiving the person is, in some real way, firing the Critic's voice writer. This is — this is the kind of insight that adult therapists describe to their forty-year-old patients. You are fifteen. You did it on your own. You did it in a thirty-minute class period.*

Priya said, Ms. Calloway. *I have been working on the Critic for five years.*

Ms. Calloway said, Priya. *The five years of work made today's insight possible. The five years built the readiness. The five years are the reason the thirty minutes worked.*

She said, Priya. *I want you to do one more thing.*

Priya said, yes.

Ms. Calloway said, *I want you to test it. For the next week, when the Critic shows up, I want you to listen carefully to what she is saying. If she is using Olivia's old words – the weird, the food is gross, the nobody wants to play with you – I want you to interrupt her and say, in your head, those words are revoked. The contract is up. Find new material.*

You will, I think, find that the Critic is slower this week. She will be searching for material. She has lost the auto-pilot. She will get faster again – she will find new material eventually, because that is what the Critic does – but the transition period will be quieter. Take advantage of the transition period. Use it to do things. Talk to people. Try things. The Critic is, this week, on a small vacation.

Priya said, Ms. Calloway. *That is – that is a specific plan.*

Ms. Calloway said, *I have been doing this work for thirty years. I have a few plans.*

Priya laughed. She went to fifth period.

The week that followed was – and Priya wrote about it in her journal – the quietest week with the Critic since fourth grade. The Critic did try to show up. Twice in geometry. Once in chemistry. Once in the hallway. Each time, the Critic had, audibly, Olivia language in her mouth. Each time, Priya said, in her head, *revoked. Find new material.* Each time, the Critic – Priya could feel this in her body – paused. The Critic had not been prepared. The Critic had been operating on autopilot. The autopilot was now off.

By the end of the week, the Critic had not yet found new material. The Critic had been silent, mostly, for seven days.

This was — and Priya wrote it down — unprecedented.

Priya did not know how long the quiet would last. Priya knew, from five years of practice, that the Critic would eventually find new material. The Critic always did. The Critic was, in some real way, in the writing-new-material business.

But — and this was Priya's insight, at the end of the week — the new material was going to be slower in coming, and was going to have to come from somewhere else. The new material would no longer be Olivia. The new material would have to come from, perhaps, new sources. Older kids in the hallway who had been unkind. A teacher who had said a critical thing. A boy in chemistry who had laughed at her answer. Sources from after fourth grade.

The Critic would, in some real way, have to re-source.

The re-sourcing was going to take time.

Priya, in March of freshman year, had bought herself — by writing a forgiveness paper — possibly months of quieter Critic.

This was — and Priya wrote it down — a gift to herself.

She thought, in her head, *I have just given myself months of quieter mind. I did the work. The work paid off.*

She slept, that week, like a person who was getting back something she had been missing for years.

Part Three of freshman year was, by the end of March, drawing to a close.

The cohort, in different ways, had each been doing forgiveness work that month. Amara had forgiven herself for the second-grade Iris weight. Marcus had forgiven himself for the bike. Jordan had completed the unfinished thing with Ben. Priya had revoked Olivia's contract with the Inner Critic. Sofia,

Maya, Theo, Darius, Kezia — each, in their own ways, had done their own versions of the work. Some had been smaller. Some had been bigger. All had been real.

The Mistake Wall in the freshman hallway, by the end of March, had a hundred and forty cards.

Part Four — the Grace section — starts in April.